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6 The Kin Terminology System

My method of studying !Kung kin terminology was first to gather genealogical material.¹ After I had gathered a considerable amount and wasThis chapter was first published as a paper, "The Kin Terminology System of the !Kung Bushmen," in *Africa*, 27 (Jan. 1957), 1–25. It is republished here with the kind permission of the International African Institute. ■ 202 able to place in their web of relationships all of the people whom we knew well and many whom we had come to know slightly, I began to ask people what kinship terms they used for each other. There are twenty terms in all, nine applied to males, ten to females, one to both males and females. The terms for parents, offspring, and siblings were easily learned. But the terms for lineal kin, except father, mother, son, daughter, and all collaterals, except siblings, threw me into confusion. (Henceforth, throughout the chapter I shall use abbreviations for the English kinship terms: Fa [father], Mo [mother], So [son], Da [daughter], Br [brother], Si [sister], FaBr [father's brother], FaBrSo [father's brother's son], and so forth.) I found that different persons used different terms in a given relationship. One of three terms might be applied to a grandfather, one of two of these same terms to a grandson, one of two terms to a grandmother or granddaughter. One of three terms might be applied to a male collateral and one of three to a female collateral. The terms might be applied to kin on either the paternal or maternal side. A relative age distinction and a distinction man-speaking and woman-speaking complicated matters. I did not know for some time what factor determined, for instance, whether a person applied the term *a*, *b*, or *c* to his FaFa or MoFa, or the term *a*, *b*, or *d* to his FaBr, MoBr, or some other collateral. When I asked, I was usually told, "It is our custom," but one informant gravely explained that "God created people and told them what terms to use for each other. Parents have taught their children ever since what terms to use." It was ≠Toma who at last figured out what it was I did not understand and told me what he had assumed everyone knew, that the term

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"followed the name." In other words, there is a factor, which I finally called "the factor of the name," that under certain circumstances determines what term the individual uses. I began afresh to gather information to understand this factor, and eventually I learned that there are two aspects to the !Kung system of kin terminology, and two methods by which the terms are applied. In one aspect, people are classified by their consanguineous or affinal relationships to each other, and terms are applied on that basis; in the other, which takes precedence wherever it is applicable, people are classified with others if they are named for ■203 or happen to have the same names as those others—here the name is the factor that gives them their terminological position. I call the former of these two methods the *generational* method; the latter I call the *homonymous* method.²

1. In the hope of improving the clarity and emphasis of the paper, revisions have been made in the wording of several passages and a major revision has been made in the order in which the material is presented. The section on the **joking** relationship has been moved forward. The section on the homonymous method of applying kin terms has been moved back. It now follows the section on affines. In that position, it can describe the application of terms by that method as it affects both consanguineous kin and affines.

The information presented is the same except for two corrections, a few omissions, and the amplification of several points. One correction deals with an error regarding the application of terms to secondary affines. A second correction is made in a statement regarding great-grandchildren. I said on p. 19 of the paper published in *Africa* that we did not meet any !Kung who had a great-grandchild. However, when the data on the composition of bands were all charted and thus made clearly visible, I realized that three living old people were great-grandparents: Old Khokove [10.9], Old / Gaishay [4.1], and his wife Old Di//khao-! Gunza [4.2]. I have added in the section on the naming of children the statement that, although it is not customary for children to be named for the sibling of their grandparents, we know at least one who was so named.

Several changes in spelling have been made. One is in the word for "mother." I thought I had heard "d" in the word and had spelled it "*dai*." Most other researchers who have worked with the !Kung language, however, have spelled it "*tai*" or "*taie*." Since to my ear the sound is so nearly in the center between these two consonants, I am changing my spelling to accord with the one most general in the literature. A tilde has been added to the term *tun!ga* making it *tün!ga*. The terms formerly spelled *!umba* and *!undai* are now *n!unba* and *n!untai* in conformance with the Harvard Group's spelling.

The omissions are of minor importance. Most are covered elsewhere, but one is not. It is a brief reference and a long footnote to Dorothea Bleek's paper on kin terms. I prefer not to give the space to the subject here but to refer an interested reader to the paper itself. The paper is: "Bushmen Terms of Relationship," *BantuStudies*, 2(2) (Dec. 1924), 57–70. See also her "Comparative Vocabularies of Bushman Languages," *University of Cape Town Publications of the School of African Life and Languages* (Cambridge, At the University Press, 1929). The !Kung material collected by the Bleek family was from informants who came from north of Lake Ngami and was collected in the years 1879 and 1880 (*ibid.*, p. 3).

Three figures have been added (Figs. 1, 3, and 11) and some of the tables have been rearranged.

2. Douglas Oliver, who kindly read and criticized the manuscript, helped me with many excellent suggestions for which I am most grateful. Among his suggestions were the terms "generational" and "homonymous."

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